



Building walls or opening borders? Global immigration policy attitudes across economic, cultural and human security contexts[☆]



Yvette Young^{a,*}, Peter Loebach^b, Kim Korinek^a

^a University of Utah, Department of Sociology, 380 S 1530 E Rm 414, Salt Lake City, UT, 84112, United States

^b Elizabeth City State University, Department of Emergency Management, 1704 Weeksville Road, Elizabeth City, NC, 27909, United States

ABSTRACT

Using data from the World Values Survey for 51 countries, we conduct a multi-level analysis with mixed effects multinomial logistic regression models to explore the effects of economic context, cultural context, and national security events on immigration policy attitudes. Analyses of attitudes towards immigration to date have been limited in key respects: the scope has been mostly restricted to Western Europe and the Americas; limited attention has been paid to institutional and sociopolitical features of the macro-context; and national security events have been rarely taken into account. We propose a theoretical framework incorporating three overarching contextual domains. We find support for two of the three contextual domains. Contrary to our expectation, macro-level economic context shows no association immigration policy attitudes, and socio-cultural context evinces unexpected patterns. However, in the national security domain, recent terrorist events demonstrate a consistent association with anti-immigration policy attitudes.

1. Introduction

The large scale, diversified migration streams presently crisscrossing the globe and terminating in ever-widening destinations have provoked wide ranging sentiments and policy responses. A sizable exodus of refugees constitutes a rising share of global migration flows, their numbers reaching historic highs not seen since WWII. As they seek asylum in the wake of the Syrian civil war and other protracted conflicts, refugees globally have faced reception contexts that range from welcoming to hostile, their existence and requests for asylum provoking contentious debate concerning international responsibility and the nature of nationhood and borders in an increasingly globalized world. Coinciding with the escalation of migrants and refugees seeking entry to host nations has been a spate of major, highly publicized terror attacks, such as strikes on Paris in November 2015, Orlando in June 2016, and Manchester in June 2017. These events captured the world's attention and often heightened anxiety around foreign-born and second generation individuals. Sentiments of anxiety and hostility toward immigrants and associated acts of violence and protest are not phenomena confined to the major immigrant-receiving societies of the post-industrial north. Indeed, violent protests and attacks on immigrants in recent years in the immigrant-receiving BRICS nations of South Africa, India and Russia evince a global expanse of anti-immigration sentiment into the 21st century (Ahmed, 2014; Arnold, 2015; Facchini et al., 2013). Such events, which have stoked fear and skepticism toward immigration, make efforts to grapple with the origins and consequences of anti-immigration attitudes especially timely.

[☆] The authors would like to thank the anonymous reviewers for their helpful feedback.

* Corresponding author. University of Utah, Department of Sociology, 380 S 1530 E Rm 414, Salt Lake City, UT, 84112, United States.

E-mail address: yvette.young@soc.utah.edu (Y. Young).

The divergent ways in which individuals, groups, and nation-states have responded to the uptick in immigrant and refugee arrivals suggest that attitudes toward immigrants and immigration are a reflection not only of individuals' beliefs and their immediate social circumstances, such as their employment status, but also the cultural, economic and human security circumstances of nation states within which individuals' attitude formation takes shape (Soysal, 1994). The tradition of social science scholarship on xenophobia and prejudice provides a foundation for understanding which individuals in which countries are inclined toward welcoming immigrants and favoring open borders, and which tend toward more skeptical views and wish for borders that are closed, or that offer entry only to a select few. In the words of Fussell (2014:486), "threat, contact and context are all salient in the production of attitudes toward immigrants." Aided by a host of cross-nationally comparative survey projects, such as the International Social Survey Program, Eurobarometer and World Values Surveys, scholars have advanced an understanding of the contexts which stoke anti-immigrant prejudice and xenophobia. Much of this research, which probes sentiments toward immigrants or outgroup members, has emphasized individual level insecurities and hostilities toward immigrants as they are perceived to threaten self-interested access to scarce economic resources or the preservation of cultural homogeneity and dominance (Chandler and Tsai, 2001; Nagayoshi and Hjerm, 2015). However, many questions remain about the ways that social context and social position influence views toward the state's role in asserting sovereignty around borders, delineating limits to membership in the nation, and the strength of immigration policy. We echo Ceobanu and Escandell (2010:310) in noting that the field stays quite 'fixated in the theoretical soil of competitive threat,' and demands an 'expanding theoretical range and analytical focus,' including larger numbers of countries with wide-ranging experiences vis-à-vis immigration and globalization.

Ascertaining which populations are likely to welcome migrants, which are prone to favor stringent border restrictions, and which are moderately tolerant of immigrants so long as economic circumstances are agreeable, requires fully global and comparative analyses which illuminate the elements of context and individual experience that generate wide cross-national variation in immigration policy attitudes (Nagayoshi and Hjerm, 2015). The framework that we advance emphasizes the position and experience of individuals, as well as the features of the nation-states in which individuals are embedded, along three contextual dimensions—socioeconomic, sociocultural, and human security concerns—to explain the wide international and intra-national variation in attitudes toward immigration. Our choice of contextual dimensions stems from past research which finds that anti-immigrant sentiments often stem from perceptions of immigrants as sources of competition or threat, economically, politically or culturally (Blalock, 1967; Golder, 2003; Lubbers and Scheepers, 2000; Quillian, 1995; Schneider, 2008). At present, as during times past, immigrants are also represented as human security threats, threats which subsequently are used to rationalize anti-immigration attitudes and policies. We align these frameworks to analyze immigration policy attitudes as they emerge from anxieties and perceived threat to majority group interests fostered along multiple dimensions and emanating not only from the size and composition of immigrant populations that may compete for resources or seemingly undermine the sociocultural status quo, but also from the social, economic, and political positioning of individuals within States and States within the global system. Our multilevel analysis of the most recent waves of the World Values Survey demonstrates that immigration policy attitudes are indeed linked to macro-level economic, cultural, and human security contexts. Our findings suggest that individuals' support for relatively open or tightly closed borders reflect not only their respective economic positions, levels of education, and employment status, but their embeddedness in national and global systems of economic stratification and instability, ethnic heterogeneity, and uncertain human security situations.

2. Theoretical framework

Across the globe, public opinion on immigration policy, while widely variable cross-nationally, often demonstrates considerable distrust and hostility toward immigrants and a preference to limit immigrant mobility and settlement (Canetti-Nisim and Pedahzur, 2003). In a review of cross-national public opinion data, Simon and Lynch (Simon and Lynch, 1999:458) observe, "in no country - those with long histories of admitting immigrants, those with more restrictionist policies, and those who have consistently kept a lock on their doors - does a majority of citizens have positive feelings about their current cohort of immigrants." Even in the United States, where welcoming of immigrants is at the core of national identity, there is a long history of prohibitive immigration policy attitudes, or a 'drawbridge mentality,' such that former immigrants begrudge and attempt to keep out newcomers (Espenshade and Hempstead, 1996). Those holding negative attitudes toward current cohorts of immigrants also tend to hold attitudes favorable toward restrictionist policies.

We frame our analyses of immigration policy attitudes by drawing upon and extending long-standing models in social science research which understand dominant groups' attitudes and behaviors toward minority groups as related to power relations, and the perceived threat a minority poses to a dominant group's position. Hubert Blalock's (1967) classic analysis of white-black relations in the United States introduced the theory of minority group threat. This perspective maintains that racial-ethnic relations vary according to the degree of threat a minority group poses to a dominant group's position of power, economically and politically. According to Blalock, lower-class members of a dominant group (e.g., poor whites) are more likely to engage in discriminatory behavior as their lack of economic resources leave them with dominant status alone as a source of power. Discriminatory behavior in such cases can be understood as an attempt to cling to a lone source of power. Aside from social-class position, general economic conditions relate to prejudice and discriminatory behavior as a tight labor market constrain economic power, a condition under which dominant group members turn to discrimination to maintain their threatened power. Also, population size of a subordinate group positively correlates with discriminatory behavior as a large and growing minority population poses a threat in terms of increased competition for scarce resources as well as a threat to political power, especially in liberal democracies.

In contrast to Blalock's formulation of perceived threat as following a direct, if not exactly linear, relationship with socio-economic predictors and indicators of group size, Blumer (1958) and others (e.g. Bobo and Hutchings, 1996) argue for the role played by

perception. Following Blumer's group position model of racial prejudice, perception of threat does not follow a clear relationship with its predictors, rather it is a highly variable "group feeling" formulated through symbolic interactionist processes. These threat perception processes for the most part do not occur through individual interactions or through direct experience with persons, but often instead come from definitions of group position formed in the public arena. "Big events" played out and framed in the public arena, play particularly crucial roles in determining a collective group's image as potentially threatening.

Scholars such as Quillian (1995:586) and others have drawn upon Blalock's racial threat theory in order to understand the roots of prejudice and hostility toward immigrants as deriving from a "perception by the dominant group that an outside group," i.e., immigrants, "threatens their group's prerogatives." Conceiving of perceived threat as jointly produced by the size of an immigrant population, economic circumstances, and other factors that denote challenge to a dominant group's privileges, numerous studies have garnered support for the minority group threat explanations of anti-immigration attitudes.

These studies suggest associations that are multilevel, for instance invoking country level wealth and individual level class and employment status as factors jointly shaping perceived vulnerability to group threat (Quillian, 1995). They also indicate that associations are dynamic, with prejudice and anti-immigration sentiments fluctuating as marked changes in the size and composition of immigrant populations occur and as economies experience downturn and growth.

More recent studies have shown that perceptions of group threat are dynamic, not only related to the absolute size of immigrant stock, but also linked to the extent, pace, and public framing of change in population composition. Hopkins (2010), for example, finds that sudden influxes of immigrants, combined with a national rhetoric of anti-immigration sentiment or nativism, tend to create "politicized places" where the public mobilizes with hostility toward immigrants, including supporting restrictionist immigration policies. Brader et al. (2008) find the usage of racialized outgroup cues in news content stimulates an emotional anxiety response in subjects, which in turn, brings about changes in opinions and behaviors. The ethnic and racial composition of a society can also affect perceptions of threat and anti-immigration sentiment. Quillian's (1995) research finds that the perceived size and social position of ethnic minority groups is associated with threat, prejudice and anti-immigrant attitudes. Ha (2010) finds that while multiracial contact exerts a positive effect on immigration attitudes when contact occurs between non-Hispanic whites and Asian minorities, the effect is negative when occurring between non-Hispanic whites and Hispanic minorities. Additionally, research from Israel and elsewhere supports the notion that strong ethno-nationalism and perceived ethnic minority threat are key mechanisms producing exclusionist attitudes toward minorities and foreigners (Canetti-Nisim and Pedahzur, 2003; Rajman and Semyonov 2000). Collectively, these studies suggest multi-level associations, including individual-level class and employment factors, along with a country's level of wealth and its ethnic/racial composition, jointly shape perceived vulnerability to group threat (Quillian, 1995). They also indicate that associations are dynamic, with prejudice and anti-immigration sentiments fluctuating as marked changes in the size and composition of immigrant populations occur and as economies experience downturn and growth.

Scholarly study of immigration attitudes has also highlighted a cultural dimension of anxiety and immigrant group threat that has resulted in antipathy toward immigration and associated calls for limiting or cutting off flows of newcomers. Blumer's writings are insightful here, as he alludes to "largely negative collective images of minority groups ... that are rooted in history and culture and transmitted through socialization" and which are so powerful as to rarely be displaced by contact with minorities." Adding cultural factors to demographic and economic structural forces allows for the creation of more nuanced perspectives which address the nature of in-group and out-group relationships in migrant-receiving societies. Schneider (2008) finds that across European countries, more so than low economic position, the non-western origins of immigrants serve to enhance average levels of perceived threat. Similarly, Ford (2011) finds a hierarchy of preference/resistance to immigrants depending upon the relative racial and cultural distance of the immigrant group in question. Noting the salience of religion as a cultural marker across Europe, Hjerm and Najayoshi (2011) demonstrate that the strength of anti-immigration attitudes is associated with the pervasiveness of religious immigrants or the visibility of non-European migrants relative to native-born majorities. Specifically, they find that a majority of the country is more likely to be xenophobic when a larger share of the immigrant population is Muslim.

The role of cultural factors in shaping immigration attitudes has also been explored through investigations of individual traits in native populations which speak to their ethno-cultural orientations. The modern nation-state system is organized according to membership in socially and territorially closed "imagined communities" bound by "deep, horizontal comradeship" (Anderson, 2006:16). Strong identification with one's imagined community, when coupled with negative generalized images of minority communities, of the type discussed by Blumer, may yield symbolic boundary-making. In work rooted in social identity theory, several scholars suggest that strong positive identification with one's own group (i.e., one's racial-ethnic belonging, or national identity) tends to yield differentiation from outsiders (Ceobanu and Escandell, 2010). Mummendey and colleagues (2001) make this observation from experimental studies on Germany and Britain in which participants' positive 'in group evaluation,' or national pride, was associated with out-group derogation, especially in settings where intergroup comparisons were emphasized. Correspondingly, national attachments are found to correlate with exclusionary, restrictionist attitudes. When analyzing immigration attitudes in contexts of contentious multicultural societies, this line of reasoning bears out further. In a study that compared the relative importance of economic and cultural marginality in producing anti-immigration sentiment across the U.S., France and Germany, Fetzter (2000) found stronger evidence for the latter. Observing that the members of marginalized religious, racial and ethnic groups, as well as women and the foreign born, exhibited less nativism than their more culturally mainstream counterparts, Fetzter's findings, like others, suggest that where immigrants present a seeming threat to the cultural hegemony of a group or across a relatively homogeneous nation, opposition will tend to arise.

Following Blumer's observation that perceptions of group threat take shape in the public realm, often shaped by large, impactful events, we emphasize that especially since 9/11 and increasingly in light of the several mass killings linked to radical Islamist extremist movements, terrorist events are salient factors shaping attitudes toward immigrants.

Scholars from the sociology of disasters and mass emergencies, including Peek, Quarantelli, and Drabek, note assignment of blame to be an essential process following human catastrophes—especially catastrophes perceived to have basis in intentional, premeditated human action (Drabek and Quarantelli, 1967; Peek, 2011). This tendency for assignment of blame following mass emergencies, combined with the anxiety response that media usage of racialized outgroup cues provokes (Brader et al., 2008), provides a set of processes through which immigrant opposition is a predictable outcome of nationally publicized terrorist events. Terror events themselves, and in particular their media portrayals, influence images of the abstract group (i.e., immigrants) deemed to threaten group position. Increasingly terrorist attacks are perceived as predominant threats to human security globally. These events have on several occasions been plotted by immigrants, providing fuel for far-right, ethno-nationalist movements to further fan restrictionist immigration attitudes.

Yet, efforts to model such events' impacts upon immigration attitudes remain relatively rare in extant scholarship. Few scholars have operationalized perceived human security threats in association with immigration attitudes. One significant exception is the work by Legewie (2013), which found that terrorist attacks, even in distant locations, can have a negative effect on attitudes toward immigrants. A handful of other studies have moved in such a direction, but they have pointed toward xenophobia as emerging through a conflation of terrorism threats with immigration, and the presence of Muslim immigrants within Christian majority contexts in particular (Strabac and Listhaug 2008), rather than the actual experience of terror events.

Legewie's (2013) study is unique because it used the terrorist attacks in Bali in 2002 and Madrid in 2004 to construct a natural experiment on the attitudes of Europeans toward immigrants. And, while finding overall support for his argument that terrorist events increase anti-immigrant sentiment, Legewie further observed regional and temporal variation linked to economic and social circumstances within countries. Hitlan et al. (2007) conducted a similar experiment on the attitudes of Americans toward Arab and Mexican immigrants before and after the September 11th attacks. Paralleling Legewie's study, their research found that the terrorist attacks were associated with negative attitudes toward immigrants, but the specific type of perceived threat differed for Arab and Mexican immigrants. More recently, Edling et al. (2016), highlighting 'exogenous shocks' as 'dividing events,' discerned greater residential segregation between native Spaniards and Muslim immigrants in the aftermath of the 2004 Madrid terrorist bombings.

We follow on the perspectives of Legewie (2013), Edling et al. (2016), and others in asserting the salience of events, terrorist attacks in particular, in influencing attitudes toward immigration. However, while Legewie emphasized a distant event's impact upon attitudes about immigrants, we highlight a different association, that between terror attacks within a nation's borders or directed against its citizens, and attitudes about the movement of foreigners across said borders. Such a shift is warranted in light of the chronic terrorism which has afflicted many countries across the globe (Spilerman and Stecklov, 2009), and which may have accentuated the widely disparate cross-national patterns of immigration policy attitudes that we observe in the current era. And while Edling and colleagues highlight a singular event and its repercussions in one city (i.e., Madrid following the 2004 terrorist bombings), we seek to ascertain whether exposure to terror events within a country correlates with residents' policy attitudes in a global, cross-national analysis. Although scholars such as Esses and colleagues (2002) intuited such a connection in a recent review of psychological research, the effect of terrorist events on policy attitudes has not yet been tested in global, cross-national perspective.

The progression of immigration attitudes research has increasingly adopted a cross-national analytical approach, and accordingly researchers are equipped to explain individual and national level variation in views on immigration. However, to date few cross-national analyses have incorporated emerging immigration societies outside of Western Europe and the Americas, nor have they attended closely to institutional and sociopolitical features of the macro-context which arguably influence public opinion on immigration (Ceobanu and Escandell, 2010). The present paper attends both to a geographic expansion of the countries under study, as well as to a conceptual expansion which takes into account human security considerations alongside both sociocultural and economic conditions as they inform the perceptions of group threat theorized to undergird anti-immigration viewpoints. We maintain that this broader view is suited to the present 'age of migration' that has seen immigration viewpoints polarize while immigrants from ever growing origins seek to settle in increasingly diverse host nations (Castles et al., 2005).

2.1. Conceptual framework

Our analyses are informed by a conceptual framework that highlights multiple dimensions of societal anxiety, emanating from seeming economic, political, cultural, and national security threats to the nation-state and to the security of one's own social position, to predict individuals' attitudes toward immigration policy. We reason that particular societal features that foster a sense of precariousness with respect to the stability and status of the nation, and the security of one's group within the nation, are prone to exacerbate negative sentiments toward immigration and restrictionist policy views. The literature reviewed above highlights how attitudes toward immigration have historically been conceptualized as arising from perceptions of threat linked to immigrants or minority ethnic groups. Our conceptual model, outlined in Table 1, emphasizes three contextual dimensions—socioeconomic, sociocultural, and public safety—which give rise to a sense of immigrant threat and thereby lead one to support policies that restrict immigration.

In the economic domain, a cadre of individual and contextual factors is known to produce social anxiety that stimulates restrictive attitudes toward immigration. At the individual level, personal economic circumstances are linked with perceptions of group threat. Responding to economic self-interest, individuals with lower levels of income relative to others in the nation tend to hold more restrictive attitudes toward immigration, while a higher level of education, which is closely tied to personal income and economic opportunity, is associated with less restrictive attitudes toward immigration. Racial threat perspectives argue that contexts featuring limited access to economic power are more prone to hostile inter-group relations. Following from this perspective, the country level economic of indicators of per capita gross domestic product (GDP), growth in GDP, and rates of unemployment should be important

Table 1
Contextual dimensions of threat.

Perceived Threat	Social Contexts
Economic Threat Immigrants perceived as a threat to the jobs and economic wellbeing of native citizens.	Economic Threat Perception of threat arises from poor economic conditions in the country.
Cultural Threat Immigrants perceived as a threat to cultural hegemony and continuity.	Cultural Threat The perception of threat arises from the changes in the percentage of immigrants coupled with a strong local or national sense of “imagined community.”
Public Safety Threat Immigrants perceived as criminals and thus a threat to public safety.	Public Safety Threat The perception of threat arises from recent community exposure public safety and terrorist events.

contextual factors driving individual feelings of economic threat. We anticipate that negative economic conditions may function as exogenous shocks, inducing heightened individual sensitivity to potential sources of external economic threat. Reflecting this constellation of sources of socio-economic anxiety and linkages to perceptions of group threat, we propose the following hypothesis.

Hypothesis 1a. Negative economic conditions represented by low per capita national income, low economic growth, and high unemployment, are associated with greater support for immigration restriction.

At the individual level, we anticipate that a person's economic circumstances will also influence their attitudes about immigration.

Hypothesis 1b. Poor socioeconomic status indicated by low levels of individual income and education are associated with greater support for immigration restriction.

In the sociocultural domain, previous research describes two types of threats generating concern about one's social standing and thus negative sentiments toward immigration. The first are threats based on the size and composition of immigrant groups which could be either mediated or exacerbated by contact with members of those groups. In this category, researchers tested the effects of group size, group composition, racial and ethnic diversity and the extent and types of contact. The second type of threat that immigrants represent related to culture and cultural difference, e.g. threats to cultural hegemony. Sources of cultural threat range from religious threat to ethno-cultural threat to touted threats to the “fabric of the nation” such as the nature of the political structure (e.g. democracy). One mechanism driving these experiences of perceived threat is found in an individual's degree of identification with and pride in their nation. Those espousing a great deal of pride in their nation and/or a strong sense of national identity are more likely to perceive immigrants as a threat to culture and society and thus express anti-immigration sentiments.

Hypothesis 2a. The characteristics of demographic and social structure that indicate threatened cultural dominance of the majority group, such as the presence of a large immigrant population and significant increase in the immigrant population, correlate with restrictionist immigration policy attitudes.

Hypothesis 2b. Individual social characteristics that indicate threatened cultural dominance of the majority group, such as strong expressions of national pride and a localized sense of imagined community, correlate with restrictionist immigration policy views.

Group position theory, with its emphasis on symbolic meaning and perception shaping processes, provides a space for the influence of public events in shaping attitudes towards immigration. Following from perspectives from the sociology of disasters and mass emergencies that highlight processes of blame assignment and backlash that occur following terrorist events (Drabek and Quarantelli, 1967; Peek, 2011), we posit that immigrant opposition is predictable outcome of widely publicized terrorist events.

Hypothesis 3. Threats to public safety, in particular the recent experience of terrorist events against the country, are associated with restrictionist immigration policy attitudes.

In this paper, we test the relevance of these contextual dimensions for producing anti-immigration policy attitudes. In particular, we seek to understand the extent to which people voice support for either: a) open borders; b) borders that are entirely closed to immigrant newcomers; or c) intermediate levels of restrictionism indicating openness to immigrants only when jobs are available.

3. Material and methods

3.1. Data

To pursue our aims of modeling anti-immigration attitudes in light of micro- and macro-level expressions of insecurity across multiple dimensions, we combine individual level data from the World Values Survey (WVS, 2011), with country level data aggregated by the World Bank and other sources. The World Values Survey (WVS) is a globally administered survey that is translated into each country's local language. It is one of the few social surveys widely administered in both high and low-income countries, incorporating probability samples within each country. The WVS data that we analyze describe 78,404 individuals in 51 countries and seven world regions. It draws from several waves of the World Values Survey conducted between 1981 and 2011 (WVS, 2011). The complete list of countries included in the study is shown in the tables below.

3.2. Dependent variable

Our dependent variable operationalizing attitudes toward immigration is based on individual reports of attitudes towards immigration policy in the WVS. While our review of the literature encompasses research into a range of distinct but related anti-immigrant frames, from xenophobia to prejudice to nativist sentiment, the variable that we focus upon in this paper captures the extent to which individuals favor openness or restriction toward immigrants. Rydren (2008) and others refer to this as “immigration skepticism,” reflected in a desire to reduce or restrict immigration. Specifically, the WVS posed the following question and four possible responses: “What is your opinion about people from other countries coming here to work? Which one of the following do you think the government should do? Let anyone come; As long as jobs are available; Impose strict limits; Prohibit people from coming.” We analyze this four-category variable as our dependent variable using the most welcoming attitude (“Let Anyone Come”) as the reference category.

3.3. Independent variables: contextual dimensions of societal insecurity

We capture the three domains of perceived threat or insecurity through a combination of individual and country level variables. To capture economic insecurity, we combine items on individual socioeconomic circumstances measured in the WVS, as well as macro-level characteristics of countries estimated in several other datasets. To assess the relationship between national level economic context and restrictionist immigration attitudes we include the following economic indicators: national income, the magnitude of economic inequality, and the national rate of unemployment. We measure national income using the country's GDP per capita, according to the Penn World Tables (Heston et al., 2012), a set of national economic data that provides adjustments for inflation and purchasing power. Data capturing the percentage change in GDP are published by the World Bank. Employment rate and immigrant stock as a percentage of the population are also drawn from the World Bank (2013), which compiles data provided by the United Nations, national surveys, and official country sources. To account for fluctuations in macro-level phenomena, we matched annual level or rate of each national-level variable to the WVS survey-year for that country and wave. To capture perceived economic threat operating at the individual level, we employ measures from the WVS of the reporting individual's economic position in the national income distribution, measured in terciles. We also control for the education level of the respondent. Highest level of education achieved was recoded by the WVS to a three-category variable indicating whether the respondent attained “lower,” “middle,” or “upper” levels of education.

In order to assess the elements of the sociocultural context we hypothesize to underlie feelings of insecurity or uncertainty and, by extension, to predict restrictionist attitudes, we include two variables capturing the presence of immigrants: immigrant stock (immigrants as a percent of the total population) and change in immigrant stock.¹ The total immigrant stock as a percentage of the total population in the country is catalogued in the World Bank's *World Development Indicators*. In order to determine whether restrictionist attitudes are associated with the presence of a large number of immigrants or a change in the number of immigrants, we also include a variable capturing the change in the percentage of immigrants, calculated as the change in the percentage of immigrants. Finally, we control for two indicators related to nationalist sentiments. First, we control for national pride, drawing from the WVS question: “How proud are you to be [nationality]?” Second, we assess the respondent's “imagined community” via a question designed to capture their self-reported geographic identity. The WVS asks: “To which of these geographical groups would you say you belong first of all? And the next? And which do you belong to least of all?” Possible answers include: “Locality,” “Region,” “Country,” “Continent,” and “World.” We use the respondent's answer to the first question as an indicator of “imagined community.”

The human security domain is assessed through a measure of terrorist events, both domestic and international, experienced within a given country in the previous year. This measure is derived from National Consortium for the Study of Terrorism and Responses to Terrorism (START)'s compilation of terrorist events. This database defines a terrorist event as “the threatened or actual use of illegal force and violence by a non-state actor to attain a political, economic, religious, or social goal through fear, coercion, or intimidation” (Miller et al., 2012:8). To qualify as a terrorist event, the event had to be intentional, had to involve violence or the threat of violence, had to have been perpetrated by a nongovernmental body, and may have been either domestic or international in its aims. In addition, the event needed to meet two of the following three criteria: 1) It “must be aimed at attaining a political, economic, religious, or social goal; 2) There must be evidence of an intention to coerce, intimidate, or convey some other message to a larger audience (or audiences) than the immediate victims; 3: [It] must be outside the context of legitimate warfare activities” (ibid.).

3.4. Control variables

Our analysis includes three control variables: respondent's age in years, respondent's sex, and migration system. The respondents' age and sex are recorded in the World Values Survey. Data categorizing countries into migration systems are drawn from Massey et al.'s typology of global migration streams (Massey et al., 1998; Massey, 2006). Migration systems are assigned as follows: North

¹ In preliminary models, we also included a more general measure of ethnic diversity, Fearon's index of ethnic fractionalization (Fearon, 2003). Ethnic fractionalization is a measure of diversity that describes the probability that any two randomly selected people in the country are members of different ethnic groups. This more general measure of ethnic diversity was insignificant and removed from later models.

Table 2
Descriptive statistics.

Variable	Mean or Percent	Standard Deviation	Minimum	Maximum
Restrictive Immigr. Attitudes	45.67%			
Economic Context				
GDP per capita PPP	\$8104.07	\$8574.69	\$333.65	\$35,080.38
Logged GDP per capita PPP	8.47	1.07	5.81	10.47
Gini Index of Economic Inequality	38.94	10.19	19.49	59.33
National Employment Rate	90.17	5.61	74.60	97.60
Respondent's Income (in Terciles)				
Low Income	38.24%			
Middle Income	47.68%			
High Income	14.08%			
Respondent's Education				
Elementary Education	22.72%			
Secondary Education	54.95%			
Post-Secondary Education	22.32%			
Sociocultural Context				
Immigrants (% of population)	5.93	7.27	.04	40.18
Immigrants (% change)	.03	1.10	– 3.23	3.54
Imagined Community				
Locality	36.05%			
Region	13.54%			
Country	38.46%			
Continent	3.53%			
World				
National Pride				
Not a lot	11.36%			
Quite a lot	88.64%			
Public Safety Context				
Terrorist Events in Previous Year	20.43	31.75	0	142

America, Western Europe, Southern Cone of South America, Asia and the Pacific, and South Africa, with the reference category being Sending countries.²

3.5. Analytical approach

The data for this study are hierarchical in nature, with individuals nested in countries. The error structure of hierarchical data can be problematic for traditional regression models due to the correlations in the errors of individuals in the same country. To compensate, we use multi-level models. Because our dependent variable is measured in unordered categories we estimate multi-level mixed effects multinomial logistic regression models for three categorical responses to our dependent variable. Multi-level models allow us to examine variation both within and between countries. The fixed effects portion of multi-level models estimate the variation with countries, while the random effects portion estimates variation between countries. The country-level random intercepts capture the latent country-specific effects, separating this from the residual error, improving between-country comparisons.

Our analysis proceeds in three steps. We start by examining the descriptive statistics and bivariate associations. Next, we run multinomial regression models comparing results across categories of the dependent variable. These models include predictors for each of our contextual domains. Finally, we assess cross-national variation in the likelihood of expressing anti-immigration attitudes.

4. Results

4.1. Descriptive statistics

The global picture of attitudes regarding immigration shows a great deal of cross-national variation. Overall, 46 percent of respondents replied that there should be restrictions (strict limits or complete prohibition) on immigration, while 54 percent reported more open attitudes (See Table 2 and Fig. 1). The geographic region with the highest level of opposition toward immigration is the Pacific Islands where 68% of respondents favor restrictive immigration policies. The Pacific Islands are followed by the Middle East, where 52% of respondents favor restrictive immigration policies. The regions with the lowest level are Latin America and Eastern Europe. In both locations, 42% of respondents favor restrictive immigration policies. More importantly, the differences between regions is statistically significant. Despite the prevalence of anti-immigrant rhetoric in the American media, the percentage of respondents espousing restrictive policy attitudes in the North American region, at 51%, is only slightly higher than the mean. When looking at countries, the variation in

² Small receiving countries not classified in Massey's system and the Gulf region consistently behaved the same as sending countries and were grouped with the reference category in the final models.

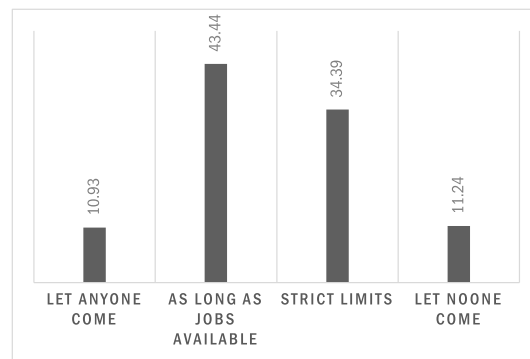


Fig. 1. Attitudes toward immigration.

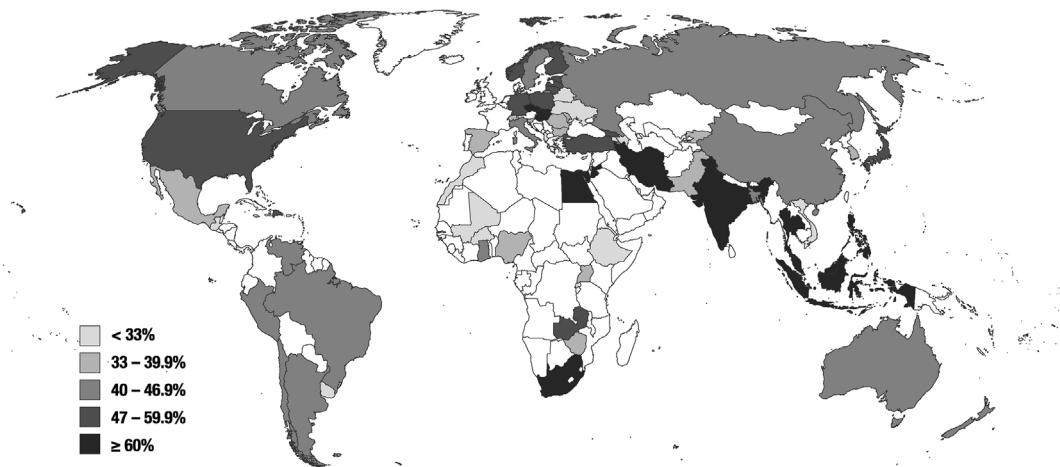


Fig. 2. Proportion of respondents with restrictive attitudes.

attitudes is even more dramatic. In Rwanda only 10% of respondents favor restrictive immigration policies, while in Malaysia 91% favor restrictive policies. The map below shows countries shaded to represent the percentage of people that believe there should be strict limits to or prohibition of immigration (Fig. 2). Clearly, there is a great deal of variation across both geographic regions and countries.

Next, we use country-level aggregate data to generate bivariate correlations between anti-immigration attitudes (the country proportion) and our key indicators of economic, sociocultural, and human security circumstances. We first consider macro-level economic conditions in relationship to country-level anti-immigration policy attitudes. A nation's GDP per capita has a significant positive correlation with anti-immigration attitudes ($r = .38$; $p < .05$). To explore this counter-intuitive relationship in more detail we examine the bivariate relationship between national income levels (in four categories designated by the World Bank) and immigration attitudes. In particular, our bivariate analyses suggest that low-income countries are the most tolerant of immigrants, while the lower-middle, middle, and high income countries are less tolerant of immigrants. In low-income countries, only 29% of respondents favor restrictive immigration policies. Lower-middle and high-income countries are comparable, with lower-middle income countries exhibiting 46% of respondents favoring restrictive immigration policies and high-income countries showing 47%. Middle-income countries are the least tolerant, with 53% of respondents favor restrictive immigration policies. This may be a result of there being fewer immigrants in low-income countries, and hence a lesser perceived sense of ethnic threat or ethnic competition posed in these settings. Alternatively, this trend may indicate that the perceived economic threat of immigrants is most salient in countries in the semi-periphery that are striving to enhance their global economic standing. Economic insecurity and perceived threat may be most prevalent for those who view their economic goals as attainable and who view immigrants as obstacles to those goals, rather than those toward the bottom, with the lowest incomes. Since these preliminary analyses are contrary to our hypothesized relationship we will explore this in more detail in our multivariate analyses, controlling for rate of economic growth, the presence of immigrants, and other factors hypothesized to influence perceived threat.

Looking at bivariate correlations, socio-cultural context has a complicated relationship with attitudes about immigration policy. When aggregated at the country level, immigrant stock, or the percentage of immigrants in a country, shows no correlation with immigration attitudes. In fact, it is not significantly correlated with any of the macro-level predictors. Similarly, the change in the percentage of immigrants in a country is not correlated with immigration attitudes. When disaggregated, the percentage of immigrants in the country remains uncorrelated with restrictionist attitudes, while the change in the percentage of immigrants in the country has a very small negative correlation with restrictionist attitudes.

With regard to security context, there is a statistically significant positive correlation ($r = .32$) between the number of recent

Table 3
Number of terrorist events per country.

0 Events	1–9 Events	10–39 Events	40 + Events
Belarus	Australia	Albania	India
Egypt	Argentina	Bangladesh	Indonesia
Moldova	Armenia	Bulgaria	Pakistan
Norway	Azerbaijan	China	Philippines
Romania	Bosnia	Georgia	Russia
South Korea	Canada	Germany	Turkey
Viet Nam	Chile	Mexico	
	Czech Rep	Peru	
	Estonia	South Africa	
	Finland	Spain	
	Iran	Uganda	
	Japan	United States	
	Jordan		
	Kyrgyzstan		
	Latvia		
	Lithuania		
	New Zealand		
	Nigeria		
	Poland		
	Slovakia		
	Sweden		
	Switzerland		
	Ukraine		
	Uruguay		
	Venezuela		
	Zimbabwe		

terrorist events experienced in a country and the prevalence of restrictive immigration attitudes. The majority of countries in our sample experienced few or no recent terrorist events. Seven countries had no terrorist events, and 26 had between one and nine terrorist events. A small handful of countries had more than 40 terrorist events, with India having the most events, 300 events during the year prior to wave two of WVS data collection and 142 events in the year prior to wave four (See Table 3 and Table 4).

When considering variation in immigration policy attitudes across countries arrayed according to their experience of recent terrorist events we do discern a pattern. On average, 40% of respondents in countries with no terrorist events reported restrictive immigration attitudes. 44% with just a few terrorist events (one to nine) reported restrictive immigration attitudes. However, as the number of recent terrorist events increased to the higher categories the proportion of respondents with restrictive attitudes toward immigration increased as well. 49% of respondents in countries with 10 or more terrorist events reported restrictive immigration attitudes.

While the bi-variate correlation between terrorism and restrictionist immigration attitudes is a moderate one, we anticipate that even after controlling for economic and cultural context, a recent history of terrorist events will be associated with higher levels of immigrant skepticism. We explore this relationship in greater depth in the multi-level models presented below.

4.2. Multivariate results

Our multivariate analyses use multi-level mixed effects multinomial logistic regression models to investigate the likelihood of respondents espousing one of three relatively restrictive attitudes toward migration. The model estimates the likelihood of expressing the attitude that immigration should be allowed if jobs are available; the likelihood of expressing the attitude that immigration should have strict limits; and the likelihood that respondents advocate letting no one in the country. All likelihoods are estimated in reference to the response that the country should “let anyone come.”

The models do not support our hypothesis that negative economic contexts (i.e. low per capita national income, high economic inequality, high unemployment) foster high levels of anti-immigration sentiment. Contrary to our expectation, neither GDP per capita nor growth in GDP per capita were associated with immigration policy attitudes. Also, contrary to our hypothesis, national unemployment rates had no relationship immigration policy attitudes.

At the individual level, economic circumstances appear to have a non-linear relationship with anti-immigration sentiment, offering mixed support for the economic threat hypothesis. In comparison with low-income respondents, respondents belonging to the middle tercile of the economic distribution are slightly more likely to favor letting immigrants come only if jobs are available. They are not however more likely to express the most highly restrictive attitudes. In contrast, respondents belonging to the highest tercile of the economic distribution are considerably less likely than respondents from the low-income reference group to favor complete restriction of immigration; the odds of an individual expressing that the country should let no one enter is 44 percent lower for individuals with high incomes, as compared to lower earning respondents.

The models offer mixed support for our hypothesis that potential sources of cultural threat are associated with restrictionist

Table 4

Multi-level Mixed Effects Multinomial Regression Models Predicting Anti-immigration Sentiment (Exponentiated coefficients shown).

Ref. Category: <i>Let Anyone Come</i>	<i>If Jobs Available</i>	<i>Set Strict Limits</i>	<i>Let No One Come^a</i>
Economic			
Log GDP per cap. PPP	.965	1.048	1.055
Growth in GDP (%)	0.989	1.014	0.999
Nat'l Employment Rate	.991	1.001	0.990
R's Income Level			
Middle Income Tercile	1.124*	1.128	0.858
High Income Tercile	1.080	0.978	0.559***
R's Education			
Secondary Ed.	1.229**	1.230**	0.750***
Post-secondary Ed.	1.249**	1.121	0.458***
Socio-Cultural			
Immigrants (% of pop.)	0.998	1.008	1.018
Immigrants (Change in %)	0.918	.883*	.768**
Imagined Community			
Region of Country	.971	0.955	0.983
Country	1.062	0.958	0.991
Continent	.777*	0.731**	0.592***
World	.787***	0.557***	0.609***
R's National Pride	1.311**	1.612***	1.310**
Public Safety			
Terrorist Events	1.006	1.012**	1.019***
Controls			
Sex	.938*	.97	0.984
Age	1.009***	1.011***	1.010***
Migration System			
North America	1.506***	2.098***	0.929
Western Europe	1.682**	1.837**	1.117
Asia and the Pacific	3.894***	3.449***	0.834
So. Cone So. America	1.180	1.230	0.943
South Africa	1.138	2.518**	2.029
Constant	5.776	.570	0.996
Random Effects			
Country Variance: .531*** (pooled across all outcomes)			
Observations: 78,564			
Groups (Countries): 51			

***p < 0.001, **p < 0.01, *p < 0.05.

^a Light gray shading indicates that the coefficients for “Let No One Come” differ from the coefficients for at least one of the other models (p < 0.05). Darker gray shading indicates that the coefficients for “Let No One Come” differ from the coefficients for both of the other models.

immigration attitudes. Paralleling our preliminary tests of association, immigrant share of the population is not associated with any of the outcomes, while changes in the percentage of immigrants in the country are associated with all three outcomes. A one percentage-point change in the percentage of immigrants in the country is associated with a 15 percent decrease in the likelihood of expressing support for strict limits to immigration (relative to expressing support for letting anyone come). Surprisingly, the magnitude of this negative association increases for the most restrictionist attitude. A one percentage-point change in the percentage of immigrants in the country is associated with a 25 percent decrease in the likelihood of espousing that the government should let no one come (relative to expressing support for letting anyone come). This surprising finding, that an influx of immigrants is associated with a decrease in anti-immigration sentiment, may indicate support for contact theories of immigration.

At the individual level, the predictors tell a more straightforward story. Individuals whose imagined community is more local or national (as opposed to global) are more likely to express restrictive attitudes of every type. There is no difference in immigration attitudes between individuals who identify with their neighborhood or town and those who imagine their community to be national. In contrast, those who imagine their community to be continental or global are roughly 20 percent less likely to believe that immigration should be allowed only if jobs are available, 25 to 45 percent less likely to believe the government should impose strict limits, and 40 percent less likely to believe the government should let no one come.

Because persons espousing a great deal of pride in their nation and/or a strong sense of national identity have been found in past research to be more likely to perceive immigrants as a threat to culture and society, we test the association between a respondent's level of national pride and their likelihood of expressing anti-immigration sentiments. This association was statistically significant in all models. Expressing a strong degree of national pride is associated with lower odds of holding the attitude that the government should “let anyone come”, and with higher odds of having some type of restrictive attitude. Confidence intervals show that the magnitude of the effect is not significantly different for any of the dependent variables. In addition, relative to identifying oneself as a member of one's local or national community, identifying oneself as a member of the continental or world community is associated with a lower likelihood of expressing anti-immigration attitudes.

Finally, we find consistent support for the hypothesis that threats to public safety are associated with high levels of anti-

immigration sentiment. A one-event increase in the number of terrorist events in the previous year is associated with a 1 percent increase in the odds of a respondent believing the government should set strict limits, and a 1.8 percent increase in the odds of holding the attitude that the government should halt immigration entirely. In supplemental tests, we found that while recent terrorist events are associated with restrictionist immigration attitudes, the effect fades over time. Events that occurred five years prior to the survey exhibited no relationship with immigration attitudes.

Overall, the results show a nuanced, at times unexpected, relationship between immigration attitudes and the broader socio-economic context. Individual level indicators more consistently perform in a singular direction. Public safety concerns exhibit a similarly consistent relationship with restrictionist attitudes. This finding supports our contention that the public safety/human security dimension should be added alongside economic and socio-cultural factors to conceptual frameworks of the roots anti-immigration sentiment.

Finally, our models demonstrate significant cross-national variation in anti-immigration policy sentiment, not attributable to macro-level indicators. The variability between countries, represented by a standard deviation of .99, is larger than the variability between individuals (.88), indicating a significant independent role of the country of residence. Moreover, the variance of the random-intercept for country is statistically significant, indicating an important latent country-specific effect that is not entirely explained by variation in national economic circumstances, the influx of immigrants or other indicators of ethnic diversity, political structure, or recent terrorist events.

5. Discussion and conclusions

The persistence of public controversies surrounding immigration policy, and the often incoherent policies states have employed in regards to immigration, symptomize the contradictions between globalizing, cross-national integration processes, and a nation-state system premised on state sovereignty and the legitimacy of borders and nationhood. In our analyses, we seek to delineate those individual and country level factors linked to various dimensions of insecurity in globalizing and stratified national contexts, and which induce natives to oppose state policies that are permissive toward admitting international immigrants. Our results find partial consistency with classic racial threat theory, most notably, with Blumer's assertion that perceive threat not follow a clear relationship with contextual circumstances, but is a highly variable "group feeling" stemming from "big events" in the public arena. Complementing this idea, we found no evidence that economic context influences immigration attitudes, but individual socio-economic status is related to immigration attitudes. Our results demonstrate, middle income individuals express slightly more restrictionist attitudes than low income individuals and considerably more restrictionist attitudes than high income individuals. Thus, while higher individual incomes operate as anticipated, reducing anti-immigration sentiment, the middle-income position may be the most precarious with regard to the experience of economic threat and the corresponding expression of anti-immigration policy attitudes. In essence, those with mid-level incomes may feel that they have a lot to lose by allowing immigration, while those with lower incomes may feel slightly less threatened in their socioeconomic position. While classic economic threat conceptualizations understand group hostility to emanate highest from the bottom economic segment of a group, we instead find opposition to be highest in the middle earner category. One interpretation for this point of distinction for respondents from the middle of the economic distribution is that it owes to middle earners occupying a position that can be potentially lost—and yet a position not so high as to come with a sense of security. In general, both the context of national economic inequality, as well as an individual's economic position, influence an oppositional sentiment toward immigration.

Similarly, the macro-level socio-cultural predictors had unexpected effects. An increase in the percentage of immigrants is associated with a decrease in restrictionist attitudes. This finding may offer support for contact theories of immigration. Alternately, it may relate to public narratives around immigrants and immigration. More research is necessary to understand this unexpected finding. At the individual level, the socio-cultural predictors tell a more comprehensible story. Individuals who express a great deal of national pride and see themselves as members of a local or national imagined community are more likely than more globally oriented individuals to express restrictive immigration attitudes.

In contrast to the mixed findings for macro-level economic and socio-cultural predictors, terrorist events operate as "big events," à la Blumer, and demonstrate a consistent association with restrictionist immigration attitudes. The formulation of public perceptions and attitudes toward immigrants appear to follow a pattern where racialized media cues frame immigrants as scapegoats in the public eye (Brader, 2008; Drabeck and Quarantelli, 1967).

To date, very few analyses have addressed immigration attitudes globally, especially beyond the US and European settings. The few that have indicate that economic downturn and hardship correlate with restrictive immigration attitudes. However, since few low-income countries are included in the previous research it is difficult to know whether low levels of GDP, business cycle downturns, and high unemployment have the same relationship with immigration attitudes in low-income contexts. Our analyses indicate that macro-level economic forces do not have the predicted effect when a full spectrum of countries are included in the analyses. Moreover, our analyses represent the first attempt to model the relationship between public safety, especially terrorism and threats to national security, and immigration policy attitudes in countries outside of Europe and North America. Indeed, our study finds that recent terrorist events are among the most consistent macro-level predictors of anti-immigration policy attitudes and the effect of terrorism on attitudes is consistent across countries.

By focusing attention upon threats to human security in the form of domestic terrorist attacks, we generate novel insights into the role of such events in shaping the cross-national contours of attitudes toward borders and foreigners. In our assessment, the incidence of such events is integral to attitude-formation, as they influence the daily sense of security or unease which average residents experience and which thereby influence the extent to which they welcome or shun new immigrant entrants. As Spilerman and

Stecklov (2009) observe, especially in the post 9/11 era, terrorism as it shapes attitudes and collective behaviors deserves more than passing consideration; our initial observation of a positive association between terror events and restrictionist immigration attitudes builds upon the work of Legewie (2013), adding a cross-national insights relevant to all levels of economic and social development. However, due to the cross-sectional structure of the analysis, public safety events warrant further analysis that is attentive to the dynamism of such attitudes in response to evolving human security situations.

While these data permit multi-level analysis across the world utilizing under employed predictors, this study is nevertheless limited by certain aspects of the data. Data on terrorist events refer to events both domestic and international in scope. We posit potential variation across domestic and international oriented events and call for future research to provide differentiation along these lines. In addition, individual experiences as victims of crime and/or terrorist events are likely to exhibit strong and pervasive influences on immigration sentiment. We suspect that personal history of events breaching individual safety will powerfully influence restrictionist attitudes. At the present time, however, cross-national data documenting individual victimization is not available. As data become available we recommend that future research include individual safety events among predictors of anti-immigration sentiment. Finally, data on attitudes towards immigration are derived cross-sectionally, thereby limiting our ability to assess the influence of within country temporal variation in the employed predictors.

The ‘warmth of the welcome’ faced by immigrant newcomers, i.e., whether the general populace tends toward immigration openness or restrictiveness, influences the tone of intergroup relations and resultant incorporation trajectories with far-reaching implications for the outcomes of generations to come (Fussell, 2014; Portes and Rumbaut, 2006). Reflecting a sort of vindication for extremists, acts of violence arising from extreme negative attitudes toward immigrants have even shown to lessen intentions to emigrate from sending regions (Friebel et al., 2013). As Taras (2012:27) asserts, the anxieties felt by precarious poor and middle classes, and often misdirected toward foreigners and other ‘out groups,’ may not undo longstanding liberal immigration attitudes. However, the danger comes when those sentiments become stoked in the public arena, and are swept into the machinations of bureaucracies which implement border controls and other immigration policies:

“In difficult economic times, citizens across Europe have developed different anxieties, fears, even dislikes and hatreds. Their skepticism about immigration is often misunderstood or misinterpreted, and the worst of motives are ascribed to them. They are not the primary agents of change, however. As a crisis of leadership, a series of governmental failures, a persistent democratic deficit, and an exhaustion of ideas have beset Europe, the unlikely actors appropriating the role of principal agents for change - and for the public interest, they are convinced - are appointed officials of all ranks.”

These results provoke a clear need for deeper investigation into macro-level factors, especially the presence of immigrants, changes to the immigrant population, and public safety events. Further examination of the role of income level and development on the relationship between macro-level economic conditions and immigration policy attitudes is needed to understand why there is no association between economic context and immigration policy attitudes when low-income countries are included in the analyses. We propose future research to assess national-level economic, social, and public safety conditions longitudinally in order to examine how swings in these time-variant factors (e.g. economic booms/downturns; prolonged periods of relative peace, versus periods following large-scale terrorist events) translates to variation in individual attitudes towards government policy towards immigration within countries.

Appendix A. Supplementary data

Supplementary data related to this article can be found at <http://dx.doi.org/10.1016/j.ssresearch.2018.06.006>.

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